

Chapter 1

I sat on the old sheet metal cart, oblivious to the world around me. I was just a kid, too young to understand the hard reality I lived in. Level twelve was all I knew. Leaving Centro, traveling the stars. That life had never seemed possible. For me, Centro was the only life there was.

The bread crunched between my molars. The softer parts were no better; they chewed like rubber and wore out my jaw. I couldn't decide which I preferred. Either way, I was hungry, and I wasn't about to let a perfectly good piece of Mrs. Patty's bread go to waste. I took another bite.

The walking pad of twelve was busy that day, but no busier than usual. I sat off to the side, feet dangling from the crude cart I'd built all those years ago. Really, it hadn't been that long — building it was how I learned to weld — but for someone my age, it felt like a lifetime. I kicked my feet absently as I finished the last bite.

"Want any more to take to Carvina or Tala?" Mrs. Patty asked as I jumped down to leave.

"I'm not heading down today. Thank you, though." The old woman was always thinking of others, feeding kids who weren't even from twelve. I wasn't sure there was a kinder person in the universe.

"Okay," she said. "I like those girls, but I don't like those floors. Thirteen and fourteen are dangerous." She shuddered at the words. "Just a bunch of criminals down there in the lower levels."

Overhead, a modded transport whined past, its magnetic motors tuned up to a jet frequency. I looked up and smiled at the ride as it passed. Odds were low the driver owned the paperwork for it. And if they did, it was probably a forgery.

"Everyone here on twelve is a bunch of criminals." I laughed. "Pretty much anyone under five is a criminal. You might just be the only exception to the rule," I said, waving over my shoulder.

I made my way down the walkway and through the back alleys, finally slipping in through the hidden door of my home. It wasn't much, and I'd probably have to move once I got taller, but for now it worked.

The room was dark except for a thin stream of light that fought its way through the gaps in some wooden boards along one wall. I flipped a small switch by the door, and rows of string lights lit up the cramped space. The ceiling was too low to stand, so I crawled to the far side. It thumped and rained dust as people moved through the building above me. A small price to pay for a place of your own on twelve.

I plopped down on a small cushion, parts and wires spread around me, and picked up the one device that mattered. Wires in every color of the rainbow spilled out of the little metal disk. I tried

to remember what each one did, but I had to check my notes to be sure before I started tinkering.

I don't know how long I sat there pulling and pushing wires before Dabs snuck up behind me. It couldn't have been more than a few hours. The light hadn't yet sunk to its low night hue.

I'd done my best to keep my home a secret. When you work with a crew of criminals like the ones you find on twelve, you don't want them knowing where you live. The last thing I needed was someone coming in and stealing all my parts. They knew I had them. They just didn't know where.

"Ah!" Dabs screamed.

"Shit!" I jumped, nearly throwing the disk from my hands. Dust puffed up from the dirt floor, clouding my vision and tickling the inside of my nose. "What the hell, Dabs! You scared me!"

The man roared with laughter. Dabsorin Facishe. A man of legend on twelve. Well, maybe not, but he was to me. He pushed up off his hands and knees into a seated position, hunching his back and hanging his head just to fit. That's how I knew that one day I'd need to find myself a new place. Just not yet.

"What you got there?" Dabs asked, looking down at the metal disk in my hands. He was curious by nature. I think that's what always drew me to him. He was also nice. Other than Mrs. Patty, Dabs was probably the only other kind person on this floor. And he was the only person on twelve who knew where I lived.

"It's an arc grenade," I answered.

"Like the ones the Corporate Police use?"

I nodded.

"Nasty stuff. I remember one time I was up on five boosting a transport a few years back and some newbie Corporate tossed one of those. Oh, it hurt." He cringed at the memory. "I thought for a second it fried my pubes, but I was all good. Luckily, the dumbass Corporate fried himself too. Knocked himself out cold. I got a nice mech suit that day."

Dabs was one of those people who always had a story for everything. And people loved him — really loved him. He might not have been the best booster on twelve, but he made up for it in charisma.

"Pretty much what I'm getting at here in a roundabout way is, be careful with those things. They pack quite a punch. Where'd you even get it?" Dabs asked.

"I built it."

"You built that?"

Again, I just nodded.

“You know sometimes I forget you’re so damn good at this shit. I’ve never really understood how you’ve picked it all up. I mean, I can mod a transport with the rest of them, but damn if I could rebuild a fucking corporate-level arc grenade with scrap parts.” He drifted off with the words.

“It’s not corporate level. I don’t have the spec. I’m playing more of a guessing game.”

Dabs laughed and scooted back just a hair. “You’re just guessing, building a grenade that spews a storm of electrical charge? You’re fucking crazy, kid.” He reached over and ruffled my hair. “I think that’s why I like you.”

For as long as I can remember, I was alone. No family in this world. Just a brief flash of my mother’s face, and that’s it. Nothing of substance. If I saw her today, I’m not sure I’d even recognize her. But Dabs was family. Something like a father. Or more like an older brother. He kept me safe and taught me how Centro worked.

“By the way, Larch is looking for you. I think he has a job for you,” Dabs continued.

I let out a heavy sigh. If Dabs was my older brother, Larch was my drunk stepfather. Not drunk on booze; no, that’s the old man on thirteen, and even he’s not too bad. Larch was drunk with power.

I knew it wasn’t a request. I had no choice in the matter. When Larch calls, you answer. That’s how twelve worked. If you had a problem with that, you could try being boss of the floor yourself. But to do that, you’d have to get rid of Larch.

“Do you know what the job is?”

Dabs shrugged. “No clue. I was just told to come find you.”

My shoulders slumped, but I still followed orders.

Chapter 2

The walkways were still crowded. People moved in clusters of two or three, rarely more than four. Very few walked alone, and the ones who did slunk through the crowd. I kept my eyes on them. They'd steal the clothes off your back if they could, but they were just as happy slipping their slick fingers into your pocket.

I still held the small disk in my hand, poking and prodding at it with my multitool. Every so often, sparks jumped from the wires, and Dabs jumped with them. I sparked it again, and he flinched. I laughed.

"Well now you're just doing it on purpose, you little asshole," Dabs said.

"No, I'm trying to be careful like you said. I don't want to fry our pubes." I smirked.

"Like you got any pubes yet, you little runt." Dabs shoved my shoulder, and the disk sparked again as my multitool hit it. I jumped that time, and Dabs laughed at me.

We walked for a while. Dabs asked his usual question about what I was working on, and I explained the engineering behind it while he pretended to follow along. I knew most of it went over his head, but I liked having someone to talk it through with. I had Car on fourteen and Tala on thirteen, but they didn't get it like Dabs did. At least he was sort of an engineer.

Soon the walkway opened up as we turned down a side street. Tall buildings rose on either side of us, stretching up to hold the roof nearly half a kilometer overhead. Our roof was the floor of eleven. Every building on twelve looked nearly the same: tall, built from dark grey concrete that crumbled away in sections. Rubble and trash lined the edges of the street. Without the crowd, I could hear the hum of the air recyclers off in the distance. I never realized until later how much I hated those damn air recyclers.

I shoved the disk back into my pocket as we got closer. I didn't want anyone seeing what I had. Not yet. It'd be more of a surprise if I ever needed it.

"I'm gonna peel off here, kid," Dabs said as he turned.

"You're not coming to the shop?"

"Nah, got to meet Cletch and the boys for, ah, something." He headed for a half-open door. White light and heavy music spilled from the seams.

Yeah, his "ah, something" was drinking with the boys. I didn't ask any more questions. That was just the way of the world. The old men drank, and I worked. I kept going on my own, and it wasn't much farther up the road before I reached Larch's shop.

It was a single-story building wedged between two pillar towers. Rows of metal bay doors lined the front. Only a few stood open, with men working inside. I slipped through one and into the shop.

The polished concrete floor was slick with grease from recent mods. A group of men was pulling the transduction rings from a Class S mag motor they'd just jacked out of a transport. The tallest, a bald man, eyed me as I passed. He spat a wad of black tar onto the floor and watched me walk away. I shrank down in his shadow, avoiding the big oaf's glare as best I could. Further down, in another bay, a second group was pulling the chest battery from a corporate-level mech suit, streaks of blood still dripping from the leg mount. It must have been a fresh find. They were probably pulling the tracker. In the back of the room, a woman sat with a shoulder-held ionized photon blaster in her lap, poking at its photon cartridge with a multitool. I gave her a wide berth. Even I knew not to fuck around with photon cartridges, especially one meant for an S-IPB. I wasn't sure she did.

Paint chips flaked off the heavy metal door as I pushed it open to the back room. The light was much dimmer than in the bright shop. The door thudded shut behind me. Two men sat inside. Larch was behind the desk, black hair slicked back, a shadow of a beard across his chin. Across from him, with his back to me, sat a man I'd never seen before. He wore a fine black suit, and his sun-blond hair fell nearly to his shoulders. When he turned to look at me, a wicked smile spread across his face. It lit an odd, cold fear in my chest.

"This is the one you're going to have take it?" the man said, turning back to Larch.

"Fin, boy, come in. I have a very important job for you." Larch's tone was friendly. I knew better than to trust it. It could turn wicked faster than a snapped hydraulic line.

I approached slowly, fingering the disk in my pocket.

"He doesn't look like much. But the boy's a whiz and the best damn runner we got on this floor," Larch said to the man.

"He's a child," the man said.

"Ah yes, but people all throughout Centro know him. They know what he is capable of. And so no one is going to bother him."

"It's your money," the blond man spat. He turned and gave me one long look up and down. "Very well." He handed a small bag to Larch.

Larch came out from behind the desk and stepped close. He put a heavy hand on my shoulder, his fingers digging in. I tried to pull away, but he drew me closer and pressed the bag into my hands. It was cold. Really cold.

"You are to take this down to eighteen and give it to Marmak," Larch said, the stench of asher on his breath.

“Eighteen,” I muttered. That floor was so far down.

“Yes.” Larch’s grip tightened. “This is a very important job. Don’t fuck it up.” His voice was low. “Now go!” He shoved me away.

I left the shop with the bag in my hands and no clue what I was delivering. I wasn’t nearly stupid enough to open it there in the shop. No, I had to wait. So I hurried back out into the streets, past the thinning crowd, and to the lift.

It wasn’t until the lift doors closed behind me that I finally looked. Inside the bag was a small metal cube, cut with perfect edges and a single seam down the center. I reached in to touch it. Ice cold. My mind raced, but I couldn’t think of anything that needed to be kept that cold. At least not anything good.

Chapter 3

The numbers on the golden lift panel ticked by as it dropped. Thirteen. Fourteen. Fifteen. They kept falling until eighteen lit up. The doors creaked open, and stale air rushed in, warm and reeking of sewage.

The lights on eighteen were dim even during the day. Very few humans lived down here; most of the species on this level preferred the dark. A slug-like creature nearly as tall as me, with two arms and a long, thick tail, pushed past me and left a trail of slime in its wake. The stench stung my nose, and I nearly gagged. I clutched the cube tight to my chest. The cool metal through the bag felt good against the humid stink of the floor.

Open sewer drains carried all of Centro's waste along the walkways, and every so often a waterfall of sewage spilled from the ceiling. I did my best to avoid those sections, but they were hard to miss. Even so, I still caught a few splashes of raw shit on my shirt.

Larch better be paying me a good cut for coming down here, I thought as I walked. Cleaning this shirt was going to cost more than he usually paid for a run.

Eyes followed me everywhere. I tried to keep to the shadows, but the creatures of eighteen could probably see me there too, so it was better to move quickly. I picked up my pace. Not running, but a fast walk. The less time I spent on this floor, the less likely someone would decide to rob me.

People know him. No one will bother him. That's what Larch had said. But it wasn't true. Not down here, at least. From twelve to fourteen, no one outside Larch's crew would usually mess with me, but eighteen was lawless, even in a world of criminals.

My mind drifted from my surroundings back to the frozen cube clutched to my chest. What was it? What could be that cold? A fuel cell? No, fuel cells didn't need to be this cold. Maybe some kind of isotope, or a liquid gas cartridge? I ran through different isotopes and gases but couldn't settle on one that would be this cold. Maybe it was a fusion core. I'd heard those ran cold, though I didn't know how cold. I'd never seen one, only read about them. Whatever was in that cube, it held my mind. My attention. And that was a mistake. A mistake I shouldn't have made.

I was about halfway to Marmak's building when I looked up from my thoughts and realized I was alone. No one on the walking pad ahead of me or behind me. An eerie feeling crept up my spine, and a knot twisted in my stomach. I picked up my pace, almost jogging now. Then someone stepped out in front of me. Fuck, a human. That's not good.

He wasn't big, but he was bigger than me. Short and wiry, with buzzed black hair and a thin mustache on his upper lip. Little acne scars dotted his face. I stopped and turned around. Two more men had stepped out behind me. Shit, I thought.

"How's it going, guys?" I asked casually.

"Thanks for bringing our bag, kid. You can just hand it over here to me," the one with the scars said behind me. I turned to face him.

"Oh, this thing?" I held up the bag. "No, I'm supposed to drop this off with Marmak." I hoped dropping the name of eighteen's boss would scare them off. I misjudged.

"Well, he sent us to come and get it. To make sure you didn't get... um... lost."

"Oh, okay. Well, I know where his office is. I'm not lost. I'll just take it to him and be on my way." My fingers found the small metal disk in my pocket.

The man stepped forward. Fuck, I hope this doesn't fry me like Dabs said, I thought as I pulled out the disk and pressed the button. The LED ring lit up red, and I tossed it. The man jumped back. And, well, it didn't fry me. But it didn't fry them either. It just sparked and smoked before shorting itself out.

I ran my fingers through my hair and shrugged. "I had to at least try." I laughed.

The men didn't laugh. The heel of a black boot slammed into my chest. A cloud of dirt puffed up around me as I heaved for breath. The cube skittered out of the bag and danced across the walking pad. The scarred man walked over and picked it up, tossing it back and forth between his hands like a cold hot potato.

"This thing is cold as fuck."

"Yeah, you got to freeze the morph," another one of the men said behind me.

The morph? I thought. What the fuck is a morph?

"You ever seen one before?" the man holding the cube asked his friends.

"Nah, open it up. I want to see what this thing looks like."

"You sure that's safe? Boss said to keep it close. I think that thing is dangerous," the last of the three said.

"Fuck that. A quick peek won't hurt." The man twisted the cube, and it split at the seam. A short hiss escaped the metal, and a cloud of white fog spilled out.

Chapter 4

I pushed myself back up into a seated position and shoved my failure of a disk back into my pocket. The fog cleared, and inside the cube sat a little green blob, frozen solid. It had two white eyes, glaring with equal parts panic and hate. Ice crystals seemed to steam off its body in the hot, humid sewer air. The men had said it was dangerous, but to me it was kind of cute. Well, it was cute until it moved.

Before any of the men could react, the little alien shot out of the cube so fast its form nearly blurred. Or maybe it just looked that way because it stretched itself thin as it launched forward.

The green mass slapped into the face of one of the men behind me with a wet thud and a muffled scream. The man clawed at the slime as it covered his nose, mouth, eyes, everything. His scream faded until there was nothing left but silent clawing as the creature covered his nose and mouth.

“Shit, get it off of him!” the scarred man cried, reaching for the other man’s face and nearly tripping over me to get to him.

I scrambled backward on my hands in a panic. The man collapsed into the dirt beside me. The color drained from his face, the once pink, pale skin turning a bluish hue. He couldn’t breathe. The alien was suffocating him. The other two clawed at the creature while the man on the ground spasmed and kicked, then, after a minute, went still.

But the little alien wasn’t done. It shot off the first man and hit the scarred man square in the face, using the same trick. The scarred man, ready for it this time, fought a little harder, but soon he couldn’t breathe either. The last man standing, desperate to help his friend, pulled out a photon blaster.

I backed away even farther, pushing myself up into an alleyway. The man took aim. At that angle, the shot would hit the alien and maybe miss his friend’s face, but it would definitely catch me in the crossfire. I dove out of the way just as a blue stream of photons melted into the wall where I’d been. I slammed into a pile of trash, and raw sewage soaked my clothes.

The little alien squealed in pain, the back half of its body singed by the photons. It peeled off the scarred man’s face, leaving him gasping for breath, and shot down a dark alley, gone. The scarred man looked over at me. And I ran.

I didn’t stop running, and I sure as hell didn’t look back. I wasn’t sure if they were chasing me or even gave a shit about me now that they had the cube. But I wasn’t sticking around to find out. The problem was, I’d only been to eighteen once before, about a year ago with Cletch and Dabs. I had no fucking clue where I was.

All I needed was a lift. I avoided the main walking paths, scared I might run into those same men again. Or someone worse. But even if I found a lift, what the fuck was I going to tell Larch when I got back to twelve?

Sorry, guys robbed me, and I lost the package and ran away. That wasn't going to work. I was completely fucked. Either way, I needed a lift. I'd figure out the rest when I got back.

What even was that thing? I thought to myself as I wandered. A morph. Is that what they'd called it? Why did Larch have something like that? Twelve didn't deal in aliens. That was seven's business. And I fucking hated those guys, selling poor little creatures to the highest bidder. That's not what we did. I shook my head. I couldn't think about it. I had to find a lift.

I moved down an alley, looked both ways, and sprinted across the walking pad into another. I kept moving, using the rows of trash and the stink of sewage to cover my movement. A bag of trash toppled beside me, and I jumped at the noise. My eyes searched for what had knocked it over just as a little green blob slithered underneath it. Slowly, I crept forward.

The trash stayed still. Against my better judgment, I moved it just slightly. I jumped back when I saw the little green creature balled up in the corner, its back still half-scorched, trying to slide deeper into the sewage.

"Hey, it's okay," I heard myself say. Why I said it, I have no idea.

Two big white eyes tracked me as I moved closer. The nearer I got, the more it cowered. Only a few minutes earlier, I had watched this thing kill a man. I should have been scared of it. But something told me it needed help.

"I'm not going to hurt you," I said, reaching out my hands.

This time the little morph didn't back away. I cupped my hands, and it slid into them. It didn't take nearly as long to find a lift after that. I hurried across the walking pad and let the doors close behind me. The morph lay nearly lifeless in my pocket.

The numbers on the golden panel climbed as the lift rose. Fifteen. Fourteen. I had no clue what I was going to do when it hit twelve. Do I take the morph back to Larch? Do I just let it go? Thirteen. Twelve. The doors slid open.

I turned off the walking pad and tore down the alley as fast as I could. This time, I ran. I slid open the door to my home and slipped inside, then dropped the disk and the morph onto the floor. The blaster burn already looked nearly healed. These things must heal fast. But it still didn't move. Was it dead? I had no clue. I didn't even know what the thing was.

Dead or not, I needed to figure out what to do. I couldn't do this alone. I needed help. I needed Dabs.

Chapter 5

Light from the bar still slipped through the door's seams and out onto the walking pad. I rushed up and pushed the door open. A gust of air seasoned with booze and sweat rushed past me. Drunken shouts echoed off the concrete walls. The strum of a live guitar and the voice of a short, brown-haired woman drifted merrily across the open room. People clustered around tables and games, each one buried in its own maze of empty glasses.

I ducked through the crowd, catching a stray glance here and there, until I found him. Dabs sat in the corner of the bar, near the right side of the stage. He rocked back and forth on a three-legged wooden stool with a glass of piss-yellow beer in his hand and an unlit asher between his lips. Beside him stood Cletch, one of Larch's top guys and Dabs' best friend. Cletch kept his brown hair short and his beard full. His heavy eyes sagged from years of wear, a stark contrast to Dabs' youthful face.

Dabs was singing, and Cletch was talking to a woman behind him as I approached. Both looked my way, but Cletch turned away almost instantly.

"Fin!" Dabs yelled. "What the fuck are you doing here?" His words slurred, and he stumbled a bit as he stood. Maybe coming to him wasn't my best option.

Dabs moved closer and slung an arm over my shoulder. His nose pinched, and he quickly pulled his arm back. "You smell like shit, dude. What the fuck happened?"

"Can we talk?" I asked, trying to keep my voice low but still be heard over the roar of the music.

"Yeah, let's talk, buddy. Let me get another beer real quick." Dabs started toward the bar.

I grabbed the sleeve of his jacket. "No, can we talk outside? I have..." I looked around. Cletch's head snapped back to the woman he'd been talking to. I moved in closer to Dabs. "I have a problem," I tried to whisper in his ear.

Dabs' eyes searched me, then the crowd. "Actually, fuck the beer; let's go smoke an asher." He wiggled the stick in his mouth and winked at me.

We stepped outside.

"You said you got a problem?" His words didn't slur anymore. Had it all been an act? He lit the end of the asher and puffed out a cloud of smoke that drifted off into the recycled air. "Like a big problem or something stupid?"

I glanced around to make sure no one was listening. "Like a big problem."

"Was it something with that last job?"

"Yeah, I got jumped."

“Jumped?” Dabs stepped forward, looking me up and down like a concerned parent. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine.”

“Okay, so what’s the problem?”

I hesitated. Should I tell him? “They took the package.”

“Shit,” he said, stepping back and flicking the tip of his asher. “Do you know what the package was? Fuck, Larch is going to be pissed.”

“Well, I actually got it back.”

“Oh, that-a-boy! Then what’s the problem? Finish the job.”

“I can’t!” I snapped.

“Whoa.” Dabs raised his hands like he was surrendering. “Why not? What’s in the package?”

“I don’t know what it is! But it is alive, and I’m no slaver. The guys that jumped me, they called it a morph. It’s alive. It killed them.”

The asher fell from Dabs’ lips. A thin line of smoke rose from the tip. “A morph? You had a fucking morph? Wait, and it’s out?” Dabs paced back and forth, running his fingers through his hair. “You said you have it? Where is it? Is it free? Fuck!”

“It’s at my place.”

“Fin, morphs are fucking dangerous. We have to take care of that thing now before it gets out and wreaks havoc on twelve!”

Dabs and I ran back to my place. The door was still shut. That was a good sign. The door was the only way in or out of the cramped crawlspace. Then again, I’d already seen that little creature stretch itself thin and reshape its goo-like body however it needed. It could probably have slid out through a crack between the slats without ever touching the door.

Dabs pulled out his photon blaster. It was a handheld model with plenty of wear. The black rubber grip had worn smooth to the shape of Dabs’ fingers, and scuffs littered the finish of its strong matte grey steel barrel. Dabs checked the cartridge and leveled the blaster at the door. He looked at me and signaled. I pulled back the door, and we slipped in silently.

The morph had its back to us. The burn that had streaked across it only an hour ago was completely healed. It didn’t seem to notice us, or didn’t care, lost in its own thoughts. Its little hands shifted back and forth. In one, I saw my multitool. In the other was the arc grenade.

“Hey!” I blurted out without thinking.

The morph turned. Dabs leveled his blaster on the alien. At the sight of Dabs, the little creature squeaked and squealed. Then it lunged, just as fast as last time. But I was faster. I threw myself into its path. This was my doing. I wasn't going to let Dabs die for my mistake. I shouldn't have brought this thing back here. I should have left it on eighteen.

I squeezed my eyes shut, but nothing ever hit my face. When I opened them, two white eyes floated right in front of me, inspecting me. Then it squeaked.

"No, this is Dabs. He's my friend. You can't hurt him," I answered.

The morph squeaked a few more lines.

I cut it off. "Wait! How the fuck do I understand you?" I could hear the squeaks. They weren't words. The little creature didn't speak Basic. But for some reason, I could understand it. Was it telepathic? Was it in my head?

The morph squeaked again, and the words came even clearer now that I knew to expect them.

"I don't care if you could understand me this whole time! I'm speaking Basic. You're just squeaking!" I turned to Dabs. "Can you understand it?"

Dabs burst out laughing, nearly falling to the ground. "No fucking way, Fin! No fucking way." He kept laughing, barely able to control himself.

"What? What's so funny?"

"I'd heard it was possible. But I always thought it was kind of like a myth people would say to watch rich people try to work with morphs."

"You heard what was possible?"

"To connect with a morph! Fin, you might have just done what most people think is impossible. You tamed a morph."

Chapter 6

“What are you talking about? I didn’t tame anything. I barely did anything with it,” I said.

“Well, you sure did something, because that’s not how morphs typically act. Usually, they are more the type to try and, well, um, kill you,” Dabs answered.

The morph had lost interest in our conversation and gone back to messing with my things. Sparks jumped from the arc grenade as it pushed the multitool into it. Dabs and I both flinched.

“Hey, stop that! That’s my stuff,” I said, reaching for the multitool.

The morph pulled it away and squeaked.

“It wasn’t wrong. I was just still working on it. You’re gonna blow us up messing with that.”

Dabs put a hand on my shoulder and eased me back. “What are you doing to it?” he asked the morph.

The morph squeaked a reply. So it could understand everyone, not just me. It must have known Basic all along.

“A capacitor ring? Why would you add a capacitor ring? There wouldn’t be enough voltage to produce the needed currents to create the arc flash,” I answered.

Dabs laughed again. “I bet you this one is a little engineer.”

The morph flashed an odd, toothy grin that was a little disturbing. Its teeth had shifted out of its lips, formed from the same green goo as the rest of it. Nothing like the teeth in my mouth.

“What do you mean?” I asked, looking at Dabs.

“Morphs are usually wicked smart in certain areas. Things like science, medicine, engineering. Shit like that. That’s why all those rich fuckers try to capture and tame them. They’re usually pretty useful. I bet this one here is some type of morph engineer.”

The morph squeaked a few more times and shifted part of its body into what looked like a hand, one finger pointed at Dabs.

“An engineer?” I picked up the metal disk and inspected the new wiring. It was flawless. The solder joints were perfect and a hell of a lot more organized than mine had been. “Shit, this is good,” I muttered. I looked back at Dabs. “Well, what am I supposed to do now? Do you think I should take it back to Larch?”

Dabs tucked his legs underneath him and sat crisscrossed, hunching his back to fit. He ran his fingers through his hair. “Damn it, Fin, I don’t know.” His voice was low and cold. “If Larch was

trying to sell this thing, you just robbed him of a good couple million rods. He's not going to be happy about that. But at the same time, now that you have a tamed morph, he could use you guys." Dabs paused, weighing the thought before he continued. "If you go back now, you're going to be under Larch's thumb for the rest of your life. You'll never get off of Centro. You'll be like me. Stuck. You have too much potential to be stuck here your whole life."

"What are you saying?"

"I'm saying it's time for you to leave. You have to get off-world."

"Off-world?" I laughed. "How am I going to get off-world? Do you have a secret starship stored at the docks somewhere?"

"No, but there are plenty of starships up on two." Dabs smiled at me.

"You want to boost a starship? How do you propose we do that? Do you even know how to boost a starship? It's not like boosting a transport," I shot back.

"No, I don't, but I bet the little morph does."

The morph squeaked an answer. I lowered my head and shook it.

"But Centro is my home." Tears beaded in my eyes. "I can't just leave."

Dabs put a hand on my shoulder. "Fin, it's either leave now or stay here a slave to Larch. He might fake being nicer for a bit, but eventually..." His words trailed off. I knew what he was thinking. I had wanted an answer, someone to tell me what to do. Now I had one. I just had to listen to it.

"You have to come with me," I blurted out.

"Of course, kid. Get your shit, change your clothes. You smell terrible. And meet me at lift six in half an hour." Dabs smiled as he crawled out.

I packed my few belongings into a small tote bag and threw it over my shoulder. It took a few choice words to pry the multitool away from the little morph, but eventually it listened and came along. I tried to tuck it into the bag with my stuff, but it refused. Instead, it nestled itself up in my hair. I pulled up my hood to hide the little alien from prying eyes as we made our way to the lift.

I avoided the walking pads as much as possible. Twelve's alleys were much easier to navigate than eighteen's. I knew these paths like the back of my hand. I slipped in and out of the shadows, keeping out of sight of anyone I passed. I turned down an alley and heard hushed voices from around a corner. I pressed myself against the wall and peered out.

The golden-blond man from Larch's office stood facing my way, talking to a short, wiry man. The build looked familiar, but it wasn't until the second man glanced back over his shoulder that I recognized him. It was the scar-faced man from eighteen.

"You let him escape? Does he have it?" the blond man asked.

"I don't know," the scar-faced man answered. "The kid let the morph out, and they both got away."

That liar.

"Well, find the kid and the morph. The Syndicate can't let another one of these things escape. I'll handle the boss down here. That idiot has no idea. Once we get the morph, kill the kid, and we will get off-world."

Before they could finish, I was already running. I didn't bother avoiding the walking pads anymore. I needed the straightest path to the lift. I checked the console on my wrist. It had already been half an hour. Dabs should be waiting. I rounded the corner, and there he was; he'd already called the lift. He motioned for me to hurry. The doors creaked open, and we slid inside.

"The Syndicate," I said between heaving breaths.

"What about the Syndicate?" Dabs asked.

"They are the ones that jumped me. But they are also the ones that gave Larch the morph. One of them was in his office when he gave me the package."

"Shit, this is worse than I thought." Dabs ran his fingers through his hair again, a nervous tic of his. "Okay, we have to be quick. When we get to two, we have to head straight to the docks. No sightseeing."

The numbers on the lift clicked away as we climbed. Four. Three. Two. The doors slid open, and we stepped out.

Chapter 7

The upper floors were nothing like the ones I was used to. They were clean. Full of people. I didn't have to worry about being robbed by every man who looked at me funny, even though I still did. The walking pads weren't littered with crap. The air was fresher and cleaner than on twelve.

I loved that. Fresh air. It doesn't seem like much, but when you've spent your whole life somewhere without it, that first breath is magical. That's what I felt stepping out of the lift. Bliss. Was that what traveling the stars with Dabs would feel like?

We walked through the crowds of two. Silver-plated buildings rose high on either side of us, holding up the golden roof above. Transports hummed and whined as they whizzed overhead. Cargo haulers moaned in the distance, rising and falling over the docks. If we couldn't boost a starship, those were option two: stow away in the bay of one and hope its cargo hold had an air system.

Dabs moved quickly, pushing through the crowd like a wave breaking on the beach. This obviously wasn't his first time on two. I'd been up here a few times, but never in crowds like this. People stood shoulder to shoulder. They laughed and stopped and pointed. It was a lot. Nearly too much. I did my best to stay on Dabs' tail, only losing him for a second or two here and there.

The crowd finally broke as we reached the edge of the shopping district and neared the docks. The walking pad was still busy, but no more than a typical day on twelve. Now Dabs and I walked side by side instead of me trailing behind him. Market stalls ran along either side of us, selling bread, sweets, and fruit. The variety was endless. Any choice you could want. More choices than I'd ever thought possible.

We turned a corner, and I could see the docks in the distance — a large arched gateway leading to rows and rows of docked starships. It was beautiful.

"Shit!" Dabs shoved my shoulder, and I nearly fell behind a stand. He kept pushing until we were pressed flat against a wall. We peered around the corner, and I saw what he was hiding us from.

Two men stood waiting on the walking pad. Each wore a heavy trench coat that concealed the mechs and photon blasters underneath. I never learned their names, but I'd seen their faces plenty of times. They were two of Larch's men.

One of them was checking something on his wrist console. Then they turned and started walking toward us.

"Well, I was hoping we'd have a head start, but it looks like Larch knows," Dabs whispered. He yanked my arm up and ripped off the console strapped around my wrist. The thought had never even crossed my mind. Dabs tossed the console aside and pushed me farther down the alley.

I looked back just before we slipped onto another walking pad and saw the two men stop where we'd been standing seconds before. One bent down and inspected my discarded console.

We took a roundabout route, still heading for the docks. The little morph grew restless and tugged at my hair. It was uncomfortable, but I couldn't just let it float around freely, so I convinced it to stay put, at least until we reached the docks. I was lucky the little thing listened to me, or we might have had some issues.

We rounded a corner and came back out onto the original walking pad, just a bit farther down from where we'd seen the two men. Again, I could see the starship docks. Excitement climbed in my belly. How would we boost a ship? Should we cut the docking locks? Yeah, that should probably come first. Then the morph could slide into a panel and open the doors. Once the doors were open, it'd be easy picking from there. My mind drifted into daydreams of starships and alien worlds.

But they were cut short.

"You always did have a soft spot for the kid, didn't you, Dabs?" I knew the voice before we turned around. Dabs pushed my shoulder and placed himself between me and Cletch.

"Well, the kid is a savant, once in a generation. I always wanted to stay on his good side. I thought maybe you would too," Dabs said.

"I want to stay on the boss's good side. So that means Larch."

"For now," Dabs mocked.

"Just give me the kid and the morph. Larch doesn't need to know you were involved." The two men from earlier stepped up behind Cletch. Servo motors whined as they circled to either side of us, cutting off any escape.

"Look, boys, I got some credit rods saved up from over the years. We don't have to do this. You just tell Larch we got off-world before you caught up. And the rods are yours to split."

The three men traded a glance. Then they laughed. "I've known you most of my life, Dabs. So I know you drank all your rods. There ain't shit saved," Cletch said. "At least not enough to compete with the bounty Larch has on that kid."

"What about the bounty the Syndicate will pay for the morph?" a new voice said. The blond man stepped out of an alleyway with a small H-IPB in his hand. The scarred man was close behind him.

Cletch and his men wheeled around at the sound.

"And who the fuck are you?" Cletch asked.

“Just a lowly man that worked his way up from the lower level of Centro. And I can do the same for you men. If you help me.”

“You’re the man that gave Larch the package. Why would you steal it back?” The words came out before I could stop them. I shouldn’t have spoken, but I needed an answer. What did the Syndicate want with this morph?

The blond man laughed. “The world is complicated, boy. Too complicated for a child.”

“Try me.”

“We sold the morph to Larch.”

I frowned. “Yeah, then why try and take it back? You got paid.”

“Well, we couldn’t let eighteen have a morph.”

Dabs stiffened beside me.

“You knew eighteen would take it?”

“Of course. We made sure of it. But we never intended for them to actually get it.”

I stared at him.

He shrugged. “Eighteen pays twelve. The package never shows. Eighteen thinks twelve kept the money and the morph. Twelve thinks eighteen grabbed it and is lying to get their rods back. Then people start shooting. And we get the morph back to sell again.”

“So you start a war?”

“We started a disagreement. They turned it into a war.”

“And then what?”

His smile widened. “Eventually, once the war runs its course, the Syndicate steps in. We put new people in charge. People who understand how business works.”

“So why do you care about the morph anymore? You already got what you wanted.”

The blond man laughed. “Because, boy, a morph is worth far more than a little street war on the lower levels of Centro.”

His eyes swept across the crowd.

“Now where is it?”

They still hadn't spotted the morph hidden under my hood, tucked back in my hair. It squeaked in my ear.

"This is the sixth time they've used you? Holy shit," I whispered back.

The blond man's eyes widened. I shouldn't have talked to the morph. I should have kept my mouth shut. The man took a step forward. Clutch pulled out his H-IPB and leveled the barrel at the Syndicate man. For the first time, the people around us noticed the weapons. A woman screamed and ran. One by one, the rest of the crowd came to the same realization. Panic broke.

"You tamed the morph. Didn't you?" I barely heard the blond man say it. I had to read the last part on his lips.

People shoved past, screaming. Clutch fired first. The blue bolt streaked toward the blond man, but he moved unnaturally fast. A mech? It had to be. But how had he hidden it? Something new?

Dabs pushed me into the fleeing crowd as the scarred man fired back at Clutch. We moved with the crowd, and I watched one of Clutch's men go down, then the scarred man fell.

We ran for the docks. Without mechs, we were much slower than the others, but we had a head start. They chased us, but we had picked the route. The panic grew with every photon shot until the crowd melded into one mob of moving bodies. People screamed. Others shoved. I fought to stay on my feet. The sight of a young girl falling and vanishing into the stampede of feet kept me upright.

We broke from the crowd at the edge of the dock gates, and Dabs pushed me through. Guards shouted for us to stop, but the rising panic was more than they could handle. We sprinted through rows of ships. Silver yachts, classic haulers, and basic starships alike. Rows and rows of them.

I looked back as we ran, and a sinking panic hit me. Clutch was right behind us. A guard lay dead in his wake; a blaster bolt burned through his chest. For every step we took, Clutch covered two or three with his mech. Servo motors powered his knees, swinging them faster than any human joint could. He was going to catch us.

Chapter 8

He bore down on us like a predator on prey. There was no time to boost a ship. There was no time to do anything but run until he caught us.

The docks were an open field. Rows of starships, sorted by size and type, lined the open lot. Captains and crews watched as we sprinted and Cletch chased. Some pointed. Others whispered to each other. Unlike the people of two, no one here panicked at Cletch's H-IPB. Were blasters common in space travel? Would I get a blaster? I'd never find out unless we did something about Cletch.

"There!" Dabs yelled.

We turned down another lane. I looked over my shoulder to see if Cletch was still on our heels. He was even closer. The blaster in his hand rose and took aim.

"Get down!" I screamed, diving for cover behind the docking gear of a ship.

The blue bolt screeched overhead, just missing us. Servo motors whined as Cletch closed in. We had stopped moving. It was only a matter of time before he was right on top of us. There was only one thing left to do.

Dabs slid his H-IPB out from beneath his jacket, peered around the corner, and fired. The blast streaked through the air, burning-hot photons sizzling as they went. Cletch ducked for cover. Blaster fire raked across the dock lanes, glancing off grey metal hulls and barely leaving a scratch.

Something burned in my nose, the rancid smell of charred meat. Heat licked the side of my face, and the metal of the docking gear seared my back. Dabs grunted and dropped behind cover. He was hit. A burn had opened on his shoulder. But how? My question was answered instantly. A second bolt from somewhere in the distance nearly took my head off. I ducked. Without a word, I pulled Dabs to his feet, and we moved, only to be pinned down a second later by bolts coming from two directions. The blond man was closing in.

"What do we do?" I asked Dabs.

He grunted in pain, dropping the photon cartridge out of his blaster and slamming in another. "You have to run, Fin. Get out of here. Get one of those cargo haulers." He pushed at me with the elbow of his blaster arm. His other arm could barely move now.

"I'm not leaving you," I argued. "We're going together. I can't do it without you." A knot formed in my throat, and tears welled in my eyes.

He smiled at me. "It was never about me, kid. This was always about you. My life isn't out there. My life has always been here. On Centro. And I'm just glad I was able to use it to do something right."

"I'm not leaving you, Dabs!" A bolt pinged off the metal near my head, and I ducked a little lower.

"I don't think we have a choice; someone needs to hold these fuckers off." Dabs turned and fired a few blasts toward the blond man.

Cletch and the blond man crept closer, each from a different side, each moving carefully so the other wouldn't see him. They weren't working together.

"I have an idea. We just have to pit the two against each other," I said.

Dabs looked at me. Sweat beaded down his forehead, but he still raised an eyebrow, curious what I had in mind.

So we moved. We swung wide, in a direction that forced Cletch and the blond man to come up side by side, exposed to one another. They opened fire on each other.

Flashes of blue raced over us as we ran. Sirens echoed in the distance as the Corporate Police finally started doing their job and moved toward the open firefight. Dabs grunted with every swing of his arm. We dove behind another set of docking gear. Dabs was breathing hard.

"You okay?" I asked.

He just nodded without saying anything. Blood trickled through his shirt at the waist. He'd taken another bolt in the back as we moved.

"You're hit again," I said.

"Don't worry, kid." Dabs was still smiling.

"We have to get a ship. We'll take this one. Cover us."

Dabs nodded.

"How long will it take you to get the hull doors open?" I asked the little morph in my hair.

It squeaked, bounded off my head, and slid into the tight cracks between the hull panels. I bent down and started cutting at the docking clamps with my multitool.

"Fuck!" Dabs screamed, followed by a heavy thud against the hull.

I looked up. His blaster lay on the ground by my feet. Dabs sat slumped with his back against the metal, a new burn on his other shoulder, his chest heaving as he sucked in ragged breaths.

“How much longer?” I screamed to the morph.

“It won’t take me much longer.” It wasn’t the morph that answered. The voice was cold. I turned to find the barrel of a blaster aimed directly at me. Behind it stood the blond man, his finger on the trigger. Blood and charred flesh stuck to his suit. “Just give me the morph,” he continued.

Then a blast of blue light hit him in the chest. He reared back, firing two wild shots into the air before he collapsed. A line of smoke and the stench of charred meat rose from his body. I turned to see Cletch advancing, motors whining, his blaster trained on us.

“Where’s the morph, Fin?” he asked.

“Come on, Cletch. We’ve been friends for years. Just let the kid go,” Dabs coughed.

“Fuck our friendship, Dabs. You turned against us.”

Dabs laughed. “You think Larch thinks it’s us? He doesn’t care about you. It’s all for him.”

“I’m doing this for twelve,” Cletch proclaimed. “Now where is the fucking morph?”

Dabs’ breathing was heavy now. He could barely move, just sitting there bleeding. He looked at me. “Give him the morph from your pocket. Let the fucker get his pubes fried.” He winked.

“But...” I paused.

“Don’t worry about me, kid. I’m happy with my life.”

I reached into my pocket. My fingers wrapped around the cool steel, and I pressed the button. I couldn’t see it, but I knew the red LED had lit up. Then I tossed it toward Cletch. The disk bounced off his chest and fell into his hand. He looked down at it, then back up at me.

“What the fuck is thi—” His words were cut off.

I was already running. Tears streamed down my cheeks. The morph was back in my hair, and Dabs’ blaster was in my hand. Behind me, I heard the screams. And Dabs’ hoarse laugh through the pain. Electricity danced from the metal disk, and an arc flash caught both Cletch and Dabs in its clutches.

And I just ran. Leaving them behind. Leaving this world, this life, behind me. Leaving Dabs to die, to save myself. And I sobbed.

Chapter 9

Sirens still echoed in the distance. The tears had dried on my cheeks, and sweat ran down the small of my back. I needed a ship. I looked around, searching for one that wouldn't draw attention. Not too big, not too small. Not too nice. But something that could still fly. Then I saw it. An old classic starship. Boxy, ugly, and covered in a layer of rust, with a large cargo hold beneath the hull and hydrogen-fed magnetic engines on either side. It wasn't much to look at, but I knew enough about ships to know if it could fly.

I shoved Dabs blaster in my waistband and ran across the dock lane, sliding under the ship. Without a word, I started cutting the docking clamps free. The morph slid out of my hair and slapped against the hull with a thud, then worked its way into the cracks.

I had the first clamp off and was moving to the second when a heavy hand wrapped around my ankle. With a single yank, it dragged me out from beneath the starship.

"Well, well, well," the Tetrakol said, dangling me upside down. One of his top arms held me up; the other hung limp. His two bottom arms were crossed over a thick, muscled torso. "What do we have here? A little ship booster?"

A woman stepped up beside the Tetrakol. Her hair was dark brown or black, depending on how the light hit it, pulled back into a tight bun. Her face was cold and stoic, but something behind her eyes was comforting.

Two more people walked up behind them. An old man in a stained white shirt with a belly that barely fit beneath it, and a mysterious blonde woman with a book in her hands.

"Found yourself a little Centro lower-level rat," the blonde woman said. "Got some blood on him too. You hurt, kid?"

I shook my head.

The old man looked past me at the cut docking clamps. "Fucking kids boosting starships and a firefight in the open all the way up on two. The fuck is going on in Centro today?" The sirens were still wailing, much closer now. I could see the flashing lights in the distance.

Just then the ship behind me clicked, and the cargo door swung down to the ground with a hydraulic hiss. The morph hung in the open doorway, squeaking and boasting about getting it open. Then it saw us and went quiet.

"Is that a morph?" the blonde woman asked.

"It sure looks like it," the other woman answered. Then she looked at me. "Who the hell are you, kid?"

"Fin," I answered.

"Is that your morph?"

I nodded, still hanging upside down.

"No way some lower-level Centro kid has a morph. People would be killing for that thing," the old man said.

The woman with the dark hair glanced over her shoulder at the flashing lights of the Corporates, right where I'd left Dabs and Cletch.

"What were you doing with our ship?"

I didn't answer.

"He was obviously about to steal it," the Tetrakol answered for me.

I looked away.

"Why?" the woman asked.

"I... I needed to get off-world," I finally answered.

She looked over her shoulder again. Two Corporate Police were walking down the row of ships, their white mechs whining with every step, their faces hidden behind mirror-black helmets. The woman turned back and caught me staring at them. Then her eyes shifted to the blaster in my waistband, then dropped to the multitool in my hand.

"You some type of engineer, Fin?" She ignored the blaster. "What level are you from?"

"Twelve."

She thought for a moment, then turned to the Tetrakol. "We could use an engineer," she muttered.

The Tetrakol shrugged. "Those coils need to be replaced, and I don't know if I can do it. It'd be nice to have some help."

"You've got to be fucking kidding. This fucking kid was trying to boost the ship," the fat old man said.

"Why you running, kid?" The woman asked, ignoring the old man's complaints.

"The bosses. The Syndicate. All of it." My eyes shifted back to the morph for a beat.

The woman laughed. "Running from the Syndicate. You'd fit right in with us. You still want to get off-world, kid?"

The Tetrakol set me down. I kept my eyes on the two Corporates behind them.

“Yes, please!” I begged.

“We need an engineer. You think you can replace some hydrogen coils?” the woman asked.

The morph squeaked, rushed over, and plopped back down in my hair.

“We can replace them, no problem!” I said.

“Perfect,” the woman said, a smile crossing her face. “Well, I’m Captain Yara Mar. This is my first mate Vox.” She gestured to the Tetrakol. “And this is Doc, our doctor.” The blonde woman smiled. “And Trek, our navigator.” The old man pushed past us and up the cargo ramp.

“I’m Fin, and this is...” I looked up at the morph in my hair. “Shit, I never asked you your name. Wait, do you have a name?”

The little morph squeaked.

I turned back to Captain Yara. “And this is Gunner.”

“Well, Fin, Gunner, welcome to the Salted Star crew.”